

# A Linguistic Appraisal of Culinary Discourse on the Instagram Page of Some Nigerian Food Influencers

Perpetua Chinyere Eze-Peter & Chidinma Charity Nlemchukwu  
English Programme, Bowen University, Iwo

## Abstract

Culinary discourse provides a lens for examining how language encodes emotion, evaluation, and cultural meaning in food experiences. This study investigates how taste is constructed in digital culinary discourse through Instagram-based food reviews by Nigerian content creators. Against the backdrop of a growing shift from traditional food criticism to participatory digital media, the study examines how food influencers deploy language to evaluate, describe, and position culinary experiences for their audiences. Data comprise nine (9) purposively selected video reviews by three Nigerian food critics reflecting authentic, real-time culinary experiences with foods from diverse regions in Nigeria. These videos were got from the Instagram handles of the food influencers, were transcribed and analysed. The study adopts a qualitative approach within the framework of Appraisal Theory and Systemic Functional Linguistics. Adopting a qualitative approach within the framework of Discourse Analysis, the study analyzes selected Instagram videos produced by Uju Amaechi, Brian Nwana, and Timi Agbaje. Findings show that the food influencers systematically deploy nominal, adjectival, and adverbial groups to construct evaluation, with affective expressions occurring more frequently than judgment and appreciation. Intensification and gradation resources are widely used to amplify both positive and negative assessments, often resulting in hybrid evaluations. The analysis further reveals that food reviews are deeply shaped by cultural context, as critics draw on shared knowledge of Nigerian dishes to interpret taste, quality, and authenticity. The study argues that social media food reviews function as culturally embedded evaluative practices, extending beyond taste assessment to reflect identity, emotion, and socio-cultural values in contemporary Nigerian culinary discourse.

**Keywords:** Digital culinary discourse, Appraisal Theory, evaluative language, Nigerian food influencers, social media discourse, Instagram food reviews.

## Introduction

Food, as an essential component needed for daily survival, has cultural and social roots. According to Atkins and Bowler (2016) it is a necessity which represents the beliefs, values and identify of a society. 'Food culture which refers to the view of people towards food and how it is prepared and consumed is an important aspect of social self-identification'. Belasco (2008) asserts that food choices are influenced by cultural practices, geographical locations and historical events. Tribaldos et al (2018) opine that the sustainability of some African meals like millet, yam, cassava among others is due to cultural resilience. Thus, food preparation methods like pounding, boiling, steaming among other methods reflect the continent's unique cooking culture. Some African foods like 'swallow' and 'soup' are not just nutritional and popular among African people but is symbolic because of the cultural significance and identity. Swallow is a term used to refer to any solid starchy food

that can be accompanied with soup like *egusi*, *okra*, *vegetable*, *ewedu*, *ogbono* to mention just a few Nigerian soups. Swallows and soups are but a part African's food delicacy. Other parts of Africa are known for their unique dishes like jollof rice from West Africa, 'injera' from Ethiopia, and 'chakalaka' from Southern Africa. Thus, Tribaldos et al. (2018) opine that there should be an incorporation of traditional foods into sustainable diets for humanity thereby encouraging the continuity of the African cooking heritage. Information on food discourse can be found on the internet through several social media platforms like YouTube which represents an asynchronous mode of computer-mediated communication (CMC).

Food has long been recognized as a culturally loaded semiotic resource through which identity, taste, and social values are constructed. In earlier studies of food communication, emphasis was placed on institutional forms of food writing such as restaurant reviews in newspapers and magazines, where professional critics mediated public judgment of culinary quality. However, with the rise of digital media, the authority over food evaluation has become increasingly decentralized and participatory. Scholars have noted that contemporary food discourse is now significantly shaped by digital platforms and user-generated content. Rousseau (2012) in *Food Media* argues that food communication has expanded beyond traditional print journalism into a broader media ecology where celebrity chefs, bloggers, and everyday users participate in the production of culinary meaning. Similarly, Burgess and Green (2009) in *YouTube: Online Video and Participatory Culture* demonstrate how online video platforms enable participatory cultural production, allowing non-institutional actors to assume roles of cultural commentary and evaluation. Within this emerging digital environment, influencers occupy a significant position as mediators of taste and consumption.

Marwick (2015) explains that social media operates within an "attention economy" where visibility and affective engagement shape influence and authority. In this context, food influencers do not merely describe food; they actively construct evaluative meanings that shape audience perception and consumption practices. New media studies like that of Lindstrom et al (2021) outlines how an algorithm's reward of a behaviour triggers how quickly that behaviour is repeated. Aligning with this, Metzler and Garcia's (2023) suggest that the use of algorithms are not just useful in reducing information overload but could have negative effects on mental health like increasing anxiety, depression, body dissatisfaction, poor sleep, fueling addiction, breeding unhealthy social comparisons amongst others. Algorithms are also used in data processing and content presentation to digital media users. Digital media thus, allows opportunities for observation of oneself, freedom for others to present themselves, provide feedbacks and adapt. It also offers social groups an avenue for status competition. This reveals that digital media can strengthen or weaken digital media users' resolve to make decisions about products or services.

Despite this growing body of work, there remains a relative paucity of studies that focus specifically on how Nigerian food influencers construct taste through language on Instagram. Most existing research has focused on food culture, identity, or media representation, with limited attention to the linguistic strategies through which evaluation is performed in digital culinary spaces. This study addresses this gap by examining Instagram food reviews produced by Uju Amaechi, Brian Nwana, and Timi

Agbaje through the lens of Appraisal Theory (Martin & White, 2005) and Systemic Functional Linguistics, exploring how language, emotion, and culture intersect to construct evaluative meaning. The aim was to identify how these linguistic choices contribute to the construction of taste and the positioning of culinary experiences in digital discourse. In doing so, it contributes to digital discourse studies, pragmatics, and food studies, providing insight into how online food reviews reflect identity, credibility, and cultural knowledge. It investigates how evaluative language is used to construct taste and position culinary experiences within Nigeria's digital foodscape.

### **Linguistic Studies on Food Discourse**

Wislocka Breit (2014) undertook a comparative study of writers' review language used in the description of wine (in wine tasting sheets) in English and Spanish. A wine tasting sheet is a form where wine experts write about the taste, smell, and look of a wine. The way wine is described can change how people feel about it and even how much they want to buy it. Martin and White's Appraisal Theory was used to explain how people show feelings and opinions in writing. The three aspects of the theory were deployed which are Affect, Judgement and Appreciation. The unique role of language and culture in wine description was researched on by comparing Spanish and English wine tasting sheets to show the different ways words are used. The findings reveal that English wine descriptions are more creative and expressive, used phrases like "a burst of cherry flavour" or "a touch of elegance." Spanish wine descriptions on the other hand are direct and simple, often focusing on facts about the wine, like how it was made or its colour. Data for the study were extracted from 110 wine tasting sheets from Spain, Australia, California, and New Zealand. A computer program called WordSmith Tools was used to study the words used in each tasting sheet. The study also counted how often some words appeared and how they were different in English and Spanish. The research broadens understanding on the role of language in wine description. It also aids an easy description of wine sellers, writers, and translators to different people. The study reveal that most words used in wine tasting sheets are positive because wine companies want to describe their wine as tasty and unique.

Breur (2019) explores the diverse methods of writing restaurant reviews. The study investigates the reasons for writers' employment of diverse writing methods which could be out of obligation as a job, a hobby or merely sharing one's experiences about food restaurants. The genre theory was used to understand the organisation and types of writing by different writers on food restaurants. A comparison is made of the restaurant reviews of professional critics, experienced customers, and regular customers to assess the similarity or divergence in writing. Its findings reveal that professional critics' writings involve long, detailed reviews with careful description about the restaurants. The review writings of regular customers are shorter and focus more on their opinions while experienced customers do not write like professionals but write in a way that is similar to regular customers. The study concluded that restaurant reviews are very important because they help people decide where to eat. It also aids in understanding how different reviews work and the responses of restaurant owners. It further reveals the difference in writing between professional critics and regular customers and how restaurant reviews can affect a restaurant's reputation.

Al-Azzawi and Abdulameer (2020) focused on language use in selected food recipes. It explored the use of "directives," (which are words that give instructions, like "chop the onions" or "bake for 20 minutes") in food recipes. The theoretical framework used was the model of Speech Act Theory by Searle (1975). This theory explains that words can indicate actions, not just give information. The methodology involved a collection of different recipes from popular cooking websites to see how instructions are written to guide people in cooking. The results indicate that directives (instructions) are the most common type of speech acts in recipes. It appeared 43 times, that is 68.2% in the research.

Oh and Kim (2021) explored restaurant review writers' expression of emotions about fine dining restaurants. This study looked at the words people use in their reviews and how they show their feelings about their dining experiences. It deployed Cognitive Appraisal Theory, which explains that emotions come from how people judge a situation. If the food is delicious and the service is excellent, they feel joyful. But if the food is bad or the staff is rude, they feel anger, sadness, or disgust. This study also used machine learning, a technology that helps computers learn from large amounts of data. Instead of reading thousands of reviews one by one, the computer program looked for patterns and groups reviews based on emotions like joy, sadness, anger, surprise, and disgust. The study identified specific emotions in reviews and connected them to important factors like food quality, service, and restaurant reputation. The findings showed that joy is the most common emotion in fine dining restaurant reviews. Many customers like to share positive experiences about tasty food, good service, and a beautiful restaurant setting. However, some reviews showed sadness, disgust, or anger when people were disappointed by the food, experienced bad service, or felt the restaurant was too expensive. Some customers also felt surprised, either in a good way (better food than expected) or a bad way (unexpected extra charges). The study aided a better understanding of how restaurant reviews influence peoples' choices. A good review can bring more customers to a restaurant, while a bad review can drive them away. The study also helps restaurant owners see what customers like and what they need to improve. A total number of 2,118 restaurant reviews from TripAdvisor constituted the data for the study. Machine learning was employed to analyse the reviews and uncover the emotions in them. They also used semantic network analysis to find the most common words people use when talking about their fine dining experience.

Huseynova et al (2022) examined the persuasive language of hotel and fast-food restaurant advertisements. The study showed how advertisements are used by companies to attract customers and encourage them to buy food or book hotel rooms. The words used in these advertisements could influence peoples' choices. It explored the language used in hotels and fast-food slogans that make them sound more appealing. The study was based on Critical Discourse Analysis (CDA) helped explain how words are used to persuade people. The research looked at 50 slogans (25 from hotels and 25 from fast-food restaurants) to investigate how businesses use language to affect customers' opinions. The role of language in persuasion or even manipulation of people was highlighted. It was found that the most common persuasive technique in both hotel and fast-food advertisement was "we are different and unique". This made customers believe the product or service was special. While Fast-food advertisement often used vague words that sound good but do not give clear details, hotel advertisement used customer

compliments to make guests feel valued. It was also discovered that words that create confidence and excitement are the most used in both hotel and fast-food advertisements. The methodology for the study were 50 slogans from well-known hotel and fast-food brands, such as McDonald's, KFC, Hilton, and Sheraton. The selected slogans were analysed using Critical Discourse Analysis to assess the role of language in influencing customers' decisions.

Akintode (2023) examined the use of language and visuals in grocery advertisements in Nigerian newspapers and billboards. It focused on how advertisers use words, images, and signs to influence people's decisions. The theoretical framework deployed was Speech Act theory and Pragmatic Act Theory. Speech Acts Theory explains that words do more than provide information. They can convince, command, or encourage action. Pragmatic Act theory explains how meaning depends on context, such as the signs, colours, and pictures in advertisements to make messages stronger. The research included fifteen (15) grocery advertisements from The Punch newspaper and billboards in Lagos. In addition to words, symbols, colours, and images, played an important role in making advertisements more convincing and engaging. Grocery advertisements often bent grammar rules, used bold claims, and emphasized benefits to attract attention.

Linh and Quynh (2024) examined the feelings of restaurant review writers while exploring the words people used in their reviews and how they expressed their feelings. It deployed the Appraisal theory, by Martin and White (2005) which describes how people show emotions and opinions in their writings. It divides feelings into three parts. The first part is Affect, which is how people show emotions like happiness or disappointment. The second part is Judgment, which is how people talk about others, for instance if the staff was friendly or rude. The third part is Appreciation, which is how people describe things, like saying 'The food was tasty' or 'The restaurant was beautiful'. The study focused on the specific words and sentence structures used by people to express their feelings. It created a better understanding on how the language in restaurant reviews affects peoples' opinions about restaurants. The findings of this study showed that most restaurant reviews are positive, that is people write more good things than bad things. People often used more adjectives and noun phrases, such as "delicious food" or "great service," than verbs or adverbs. Also, the reviews mostly focused on describing the food and restaurant environments rather than talking about the staff. The study highlighted the influence of restaurant reviews on customers' choices. A positive review attracted more customers while a negative review drove customers away. Reviews were also necessary as it aided an understanding of the customers' preference which enforced an improvement in goods and services. A corpus-based approach was employed, where a total of four hundred (400) restaurant reviews were collected from popular websites like TripAdvisor, Zomato, Fine Dining Explorer, The Infatuation, and Great British Chefs. Some of these reviews were written by professional food critics, while others were from regular customers. Sketch Engine as an analytical tool was utilised to account for the recurrence of certain words and phrases in the selected reviews.

Kadri (n.d) studied the creative use of words by fast food companies in online advertisements. Fast food businesses spent a lot on advertising, using social media, TV, and posters to attract buyers. The study focused on the words used in fast food

advertisements and how the words encouraged people to buy food. It is based on the model of Speech Act Theory, developed by Searle (1969) and expanded by Simona and Dejica-Cartis (2014). The theory explains that words do more than give information; they can persuade, direct, or influence people. Simona and Dejica-Cartis identified sixteen speech acts, including persuasion, direction, and promises. This study focused more on the frequently used words and examined which ones appear most often in fast food advertisements. While earlier studies mostly focused on the pictures in advertisements; this study looks more closely at the words used, especially in fast food advertisements. The methodology for the study included eleven (11) advertisements from the Facebook pages of McDonald's, KFC, Subway, Pizza Hut, and Burger King, analysed using Speech Act Theory. The most commonly used speech act was directives, where advertisements tell people what to do (e.g. "Try it today!") while the least used was commissives, likely because companies avoid making promises they may not keep. KFC advertisements connected more with current events, like exams or holidays, while McDonald's advertisements were more consistent, always ending with a call to action. The study identified the influence of language in fast food advertisements while showing how companies used different words to attract customers. The findings revealed that only six (6) out of the identified sixteen (16) speech acts were used in the study.

While Wislocka Breit (2014) engaged in a comparison between wine tasting sheets in English and Spanish to reveal how food related expressions differ based on culture. Breur (2019) investigated the writing styles of restaurant reviews considering the unique expressions of professional critics, experienced customers, and casual diners. Unuabonah (2018) researched bloggers' attitude, (that is the) emotive responses toward food and bloggers judgment and appreciation of food (based on reaction, composition and valuation). The study also considered the bloggers' engagement (which entails proclaiming and disclaiming) entertain and attribution elements. Oh, and Kim (2021) on the other hand identified the role of emotions in fine dining reviews revealing that joy and satisfaction are the most common responses. Akintode's (2023) study focused on Nigerian food vendors' use of social expressions and code switching in connecting with their audience.

Linh and Quynh Hoa (2024) examined the use of emotions and evaluation in restaurant reviews revealing a preference for adjectives and positive comments. Through these studies, there is a better understanding of how language is used in food communication. While Unuabonah (2018) analysed the attitude (emotion, judgment and appreciation) and engagement of food bloggers. This current study focuses on the context and appraisal choices (attitude/emotions) of food influencers feedbacks as not many studies have considered the language of food influencers particularly in Nigeria to consider how language is used to express emotions and cultural nuances. This is necessitated because food should not be about the looks and aroma but how well the preparation and taste fits into the cultural context of its native consumers. Traditional foods reflect cultural identities, memories and deeper feelings. This study fills the lacuna by assessing the context and appraisal choices (expressed through language) of Nigerian food influencers in their reviews and how this reveals their food experiences and emotions. Thus, the aim of the study is to investigate the role of language and context in food influencers' assessment of selected Nigerian dishes. The specific objectives are to

identify the language of evaluation via the syntactic features. The second and third objectives are to investigate the evaluation strategies and explore the contextual and cultural embeddedness of the reviews.

Remley et al (2013) studied the promotion of nutrition and long-term food security through choice pantry development. The focus of the study was on improving food pantries' support of people who do not have enough to eat. Food pantries are known to give out already-packed food, but this approach does not always meet peoples' needs, especially when it comes to health or cultural preferences. Thus, a better model called the Rainbow of colours choice pantry was introduced where rather than receive random food, people were allowed to choose what they wanted as found in a grocery store. They used colour labels based on food groups from *MyPlate*, which helped people learn about healthy eating while making their choices. The pantry also had trained volunteers who gave advice on food and held cooking demonstrations. The findings revealed that food is not just to be eaten, but it can also be used to support peoples' well-being and help them live healthier lives.

Darkwa (2014) assessed the impact of food choices on consumers in Koforidua, Ghana. The study deployed both participant observation method and questionnaires. A total of one hundred and forty-three (143) shoppers in four supermarkets were observed and given questionnaires of which 100 questionnaires were filled. The aim was to find out how well people knew about food labels, whether they read them, and if the labels affected their food choices. The results showed that 80% of the respondents were aware of food labels, and 75% said they read them. But only about half read them regularly. Just 22% could correctly explain a common nutrition label statement like "26% RDA of Vitamin A per serving." Some did not read labels either because they lacked time, didn't understand them, or didn't think they were important. The study also found that factors like price and expiry dates were more important to many people than nutrition facts. The research showed that even though people were aware of food labels, it does not always help them make healthier choices. The study suggested that more education is needed to help people understand food labels and use them to choose better foods.

Existing studies on culinary discourse have largely considered the linguistic perspective to the neglect of the pragmatic intervention. The scholarly works of Remley, Kaiser, and Osso (2013), Darkwa (2014), Wislocka Breit (2014), Unuabonah (2018), Breur (2019), Al-Azzawi and Abdulameer (2020), Oh and Kim (2021), Huseynova, Amani and Taghiyev (2022), Akintode (2023), and Linh and Quynh Hoa (2024) are pointers to diverse researches on culinary discourse from the linguistic perspective.

### **Theoretical framework**

Martin and White's Appraisal theory is the main theoretical background for this study. The theory which was propounded in 2005 entails three broad subsystems of attitude, engagement and graduation. It deals with the manner in peoples' attitudes, emotions and evaluations are carried out through the instrumentality of language. Attitude refers to the expression of people's emotions, judgment and appreciation of things. Engagement on the other hand, has to do with people's recognition of other perspectives such as opinions, beliefs and voices different from their own (e.g. through quoting or referencing others). Graduation entails the strength or weakness of expressions. The subsystems of attitude,

engagement and graduation are dependent on linguistic devices like modality, polarity, evidentiality, intensification, attribution, concession, and consequentiality thus contributing to the evaluation and communication of meaning in different contexts. (Martin & White, 2005: 97).

Affect, judgment, and appreciation are linguistic devices through which attitude is expressed (Martin & White, 2005:42). Affect entails expressions of happiness, sadness, and fear, judgment on the other hand involves evaluating behaviour in terms of social values, and appreciation assesses the value of things (Martin & White, 2005:45). Engagement involves statements that either present a single viewpoint or recognise multiple perspectives (Martin & White, 2005:100). Some statements do not refer to other opinions, while others acknowledge different perspectives using modal verbs, cautions expression, and references to other people's view (Martin & White, 2005:97). Engagement is important because it shows how speakers or writers position themselves in relation to other people's opinions. Meanwhile, the graduation subsystem is expressed through force and focus, force includes intensifiers and quantifiers, while focus sharpens or softens meaning (Martin & White, 2005:135).

Graduation devices, such as force and focus, adjust the strength of a statement, allowing speakers to emphasize or soften their evaluation (Martin & White, 2005:135). Engagement resources, such as proclaim and disclaim, help establish stance and interaction between speakers and listeners (Martin & White, 2005:117). Graduation helps to scale meaning by making an expression stronger or weaker, depending on the speaker's intention. Appraisal theory is a powerful tool for analysing how language is used to communicate emotion, make value judgments and respond to different social situations. This study also draws on insights from Systemic Functional Linguistics, particularly its account of group structures (nominal, verbal, adjectival, adverbial and prepositional groups), which serve as grammatical resources for the realisation of evaluative meanings within the Appraisal Theory framework.

## **Methodology**

This study adopts a qualitative research design suitable for examining how language is used to construct meaning, particularly in digitally mediated culinary interactions. The data for this study consist of Instagram food review videos produced by three Nigerian digital food influencers: Uju Amaechi, Brian Nwana, and Timi Agbaje. These participants were purposively selected based on the following criteria: active engagement in food review/content creation on Instagram, regular production of food-related evaluative discourse, significant audience reach and visibility within Nigeria's digital food space, and availability of publicly accessible video content suitable for analysis.

The study is limited to nine purposively selected Instagram videos containing the food reviews of selected Nigerian food influencers. They are selected because of their representation of distinct discourse patterns and viewed between January and April, 2025. In each video, are highlights of food experiences of the food influencers. The foods reviewed include soups, swallows, rice meals and convenience foods chosen because of their expressiveness and reflection of Nigerian dishes and context. Each food reviewer commented on specific geographical locations in Nigeria. Brian Nwana (briannwana) comments on eateries who sell food from diverse regions and cultures (in Nigeria such as

Hausa, Igbo and the Akwa Ibom people (Abuja). While Uju Ameashi (*restaurantcritic\_ng*) comments on foods in the South-south Nigeria (Delta State); Timi Agbaje (*eat.with.timi*) comments on eateries in the South-west (Lagos).

The selection of Uju Amaechi, Brian Nwana, and Timi Agbaje is grounded in the documented shift of food discourse from traditional print media to digital and social media platforms, where content creators increasingly function as influential producers of culinary meaning (Rousseau, 2012; Burgess & Green, 2009; Marwick, 2015). Within this evolving media landscape, these individuals operate as prominent Nigerian-based food content creators whose Instagram videos constitute naturally occurring, multimodal data. Their reviews combine verbal evaluation, visual representation, and performative cues, making them particularly suitable for analysis. Furthermore, their consistent engagement in restaurant and food evaluation positions them as digital arbiters of taste, whose discourse reflects broader sociocultural constructions of food, quality, and consumer preference. The purposive selection of their content is therefore justified by its relevance, richness, and alignment with the study's aim of examining contemporary culinary discourse in digitally mediated environments. Their evaluative language also provides a useful site for examining interpersonal meaning and attitudinal positioning within the framework of Systemic Functional Linguistics, particularly in terms of how speakers encode appraisal and stance in food-related discourse.

A purposive sampling technique was employed to select a corpus of Instagram food review videos. The data was representative of the Nigerian context as they were drawn from three different regions. Abuja (to represent the North), Delta (to represent the South South) and Surulere (to represent the South West). The unique identity and cultural values of the regions were captured. The data were transcribed from video to text and analysed using Systemic Functional Linguistics and Martin and White's Appraisal Theory (2005). The selection focused on videos that explicitly involved: restaurant or food evaluations, descriptive commentary on taste, quality, and experience, spontaneous or semi-structured verbal reviews. The nine videos selected were analyzed qualitatively through close reading and interpretive examination of the linguistic features used in the reviews. The analysis focused on: evaluative adjectives and intensifiers, expressions of attitude and stance, descriptive and sensory language, patterns of judgment and recommendation.

### **Data Analysis**

This study investigated the linguistic construction of food influencers' feedback on Instagram, with attention to syntactic structures, evaluative resources, and cultural context. The study is concerned with how food influencers use language to: evaluate food and restaurant experiences, construct subjective and shared meanings of taste and influence audience perception through discourse. The analysis demonstrates that food influencers use language to express emotions (affect), judgments, and appreciation, often employing intensification and hybrid evaluative strategies to communicate nuanced opinions. The findings are discussed under three main themes: syntactic features, evaluative strategies, and cultural context.

## 1. Analysis of Syntactic Features

The data show that nominal, adjectival, adverbial, and verbal groups are central to the expression of evaluation, consistent with Systemic Functional Linguistics, which posits that these grammatical structures are key resources for meaning-making. Nominal groups (e.g., “*the texture*,” “*the taste*”) function as focal points for assessment, while adjectival groups (e.g., “*very soft*,” “*just perfect*”) encode positive or negative qualities. Adverbial groups (e.g., “*very well*,” “*really nicely*”) and verbal groups (e.g., “*was enjoyable*,” “*did not meet expectations*”) intensify or attenuate evaluative meanings. These are explained in the excerpts below:

### Excerpt 1

#### Food review on egusi pepper soup

*Have you ever had egusi pepper soup? My last trip to Delta State was probably one of the most eye-opening and insightful ... My name is Uju Amaeshi, Nigeria's undiluted food critic and restaurant consultant. So, Delta people have a separate way of making egusi, which is egusi pepper soup. It's basically egusi where it has spices from pepper soup ingredients from their locals called banga, and it is usually paired with yellow eba. How do I feel about the soup? **I like the texture, the look, the taste.** It's amazing. ...Like all the proteins that they put in it, **it was very rich**, was not oily, was not watery, was not too thick. **It was just perfect**, ...I will definitely rate this egusi **a 10/10**. (Uju Amaeshi)*

Here, the nominal and adjectival groups highlight key features and qualities of the egusi soup, while the intensifier “*very*” and absolute rating “*10/10*” amplify positive affect. The food reviewer is excited about the way the melon (*Egusi*) soup was prepared with pepper soup spices. She loves everything about the soup. She uses nominal groups like ‘the texture’, ‘the look’, and ‘the taste’ to express satisfaction. The adjectival group “*very rich*” indicates that the reviewer is pleased with the proteins used in the soup preparation. Also, the use of “*not oily*,” “*not watery*,” and “*not too thick*.” show that the reviewer is satisfied with the texture and look of the soup. This is supported with the statement “*I like the texture, the look and the taste*”. The use of “*just perfect*” and “*10/10*” is a judgment marker that indicates a high rating of the soup. The use of ‘really like’ and “*definitely choose*” are indicators of high intensification. This aligns with Unuabonah (2018), who opines that food bloggers often rely on intensified descriptive language to convey emotive responses in culinary reviews.

### Excerpt 2

#### Food review on pounded yam

*We tried out one of the most popular pounded yam spots in Abuja. So, Opeyemi is in Abuja, and I told him there is no way you come to Abuja without trying out the pounded yam from Mama T's Garden. Omo, guys, the pounded yam looks just like vanilla cream no difference at all. I took my pounded yam with efo and Ope took his with egusi soup and got types of meat to scatter the table. We got some goat meat, some assorted beef,*

*and some other things. Personally, for me, pounded yam is in my top three best types of swallows, so I was very excited to be here. **The pounded yam itself was very soft and fluffy.** Omo, the pounded yam was so soft that you wouldn't believe it was a human being who pounded it. **The proteins were very soft,** from the kpomo to the goat meat and everything else there. **The soup was actually decent.** I enjoyed my efo riro soup, and the egusi was not bad at all.* (Brian Nwana in Mama T's Garden)

The repetition and adjectival groups (*very soft and fluffy*) emphasise satisfaction with texture and preparation of the pounded yam. These examples demonstrate that food critics consistently use group structures to encode evaluation, providing the grammatical scaffolding for emotional and judgmental meaning. The food critic likens the look of the pounded yam to vanilla ice cream which is pure white; thus, commending the spotless colour of the meal. He further emphasises the softness of the dish with expressions like “very soft and fluffy”, highlighting how tender and smooth the pounded yam was. The comment “so soft that you wouldn't believe it was a human being who pounded it” shows that the food critic was particularly impressed with the quality of the pounded yam, suggesting it was prepared with great skill. Similarly, the food critic also describes the proteins, like kpomo and goat meat, as “very soft,” indicating they were tender and well-prepared. The mention of “freshly pounded yam” reinforces that the dish was freshly made, contributing to the general satisfaction with the texture. The rating of the efo riro soup as “decent” and the egusi as “not bad at all,” focuses on the impressive qualities of the soups accompanying the pounded yam and the well-cooked proteins, emphasising overall positive feedback.

## **2. Evaluative strategies: affect, judgment, appreciation, and hybrid evaluations**

Drawing from Appraisal Theory, evaluative meaning is realised through three interrelated resources:

**(i) Affect** – There are different expressions of pleasure, satisfaction, or displeasure which dominate the reviews. They are illustrated in the excerpts below:

### **Excerpt 3**

#### **Food review on jollof rice and spaghetti**

*...Today, we are trying Joorlan's Kitchen. This particular food box comes with chocolate juice, Joorlan's signature spaghetti, chicken, plantain, and the smoky jollof... Starting off with the spaghetti, when I say this thing is packed, it is literally packed with meat, and I'm not trying to over hype. I promise you, **listen to me when I say this is one of the best spaghettis in this town called Lagos.** If I were to rate this alone, **it would be 9.8/10 my highest rating.** Now for the jollof rice, please just listen. This is party jollof. Omo, if I tell you this is one of the best I have ever eaten, you people might not believe me... Now for the chicken it is soft, it is*

*sweet, it is just perfect. Literally perfect for the rice. I'll give it a 9.6/10... For the first time, this is the best review I've ever done. Like, the best. I'm giving a total of 9.8/10. (Eat with Timi, Joorlan's Kitchen)*

The comment “one of the best spaghettis” illustrates how the food critic felt about the quality of the spaghetti, showing high satisfaction with both its taste and the generous portion packed with meat. The use of “best” emphasises the food critic's strong appreciation, which is reflected in the 9.8/10 rating. Describing the chicken as “soft” and “perfect” for the rice highlights the well-prepared protein, contributing to the overall satisfaction. The repetition of “just perfect” is used twice, and emphasises just how much the food critic enjoyed the meal's standout features. The use of “literally nice” adds another layer of approval, suggesting the food critic's complete enjoyment of the meal. The ratings 9.6/10 and 9.8/10 reflects the overall excellent experience of the food reviewer. The repetition of “best” and “just perfect” indicates strong positive affect and exemplifies the persuasive role of emotion in culinary discourse (Oh & Kim, 2021; Linh & Quynh Hoa, 2024).

#### **Excerpt 4** **Food review on bole**

*...So, I visited the Port Harcourt bole spot located in Gwarinpa. This spot is called Plantain Palace... One plantain goes for roughly 1,000 to 1,500 naira... Anyways, we got one bole and a plate of chicken wings, which was roughly 4,500 naira. **They also had kpomo that looked very, very soft...the bole was really good. The plantain was soft and roasted very well, and the sauce itself was really good and seasoned very well.** It was spicy too, which is what we need in bole sauce. **The chicken was nice too...** (Brian Nwana - Plantain Palace restaurant)*

The excerpt is a positive emotion-based review on *bole* (roasted plantain). The expression “very very soft” is an adjectival group that reflects a high intensification and shows that the food critic was especially pleased with the texture of the kpomo. Also, the use of “soft” in describing the plantain was also said to be “roasted very well”, suggesting it was properly prepared and added to the overall enjoyment of the meal. The food influencer described the sauce as “really good” and “spicy”, showing that the flavour met his expectations, especially since he noted that spiciness was an important part of the bole sauce. These expressions reflect a high level of satisfaction with the food experience.

**(ii) Judgment** – Social evaluations occur when the food influencer assesses the performance of a restaurant or vendor. Excerpt 5 illustrates a negative judgment:

#### **Excerpt 5** **Food review on fish, chicken, vegetable sauce, and jollof rice**

***Is Tank and Tummy making our stomach a dumping ground?***  
*Because I can think about so many things that you can mess up, but I would never expect that a fast-food restaurant **would mess up fish and jollof rice**...* Hi, my name is Uju Amaeshi Nigeria's undiluted food critic and restaurant consultant. We visited this place called Tank and Tummy, Anyways, **we ended up having the worst experience...how can you over-salt fish?** Like, how do you mess up fish? Tank and Tummy need to do better. They need to find themselves because, at this point, they are definitely not having me as a return customer. **They have very low patronage, and it has a lot to do with the quality of the food.** (Uju Amaeshi - Tank and Tummy restaurant)

This excerpt is a negative food emotion-based review on rice with comments on the proteins and sauce in the food. The first query starts with an interrogative where the food critic asks “Is Tank and Tummy making our stomach a dumping ground?” This suggests a strong complaint with the use of the nominal group ‘a dumping ground’. The food reviewer implies that the food was ill-prepared and meant for a dumping site which turned out to be their stomachs. Referring to their stomachs as ‘a dumping ground’ shows the tastelessness of the food, clearly showing frustration. The comment “mess up fish and jollof rice” expresses disappointment especially since these are basic dishes that the food reviewer didn’t expect to go wrong. The expression “worst experience” shows dissatisfaction. The statement “how can you over salt fish?” is a strong complaint that highlights disappointment with the food preparation. This is supported by “chicken was big for nothing” which shows that even the size didn’t meet the expectations. Also “...this is not jollof rice” questions the quality of the rice served. “Tank and Tummy need to do better” serves a judgement marker, pointing out the failure in food delivery. The mention of “very low patronage” and “they are definitely not having me return” reflects a lack of satisfaction and indirectly warns others. The food influencer evaluates the vendor’s competence, echoing Breur (2019) who notes that professional reviews often combine affect with judgment to establish credibility.

#### **Excerpt 6**

##### **Food review on KFC jollof rice and chicken wings**

*...I was very excited to try this rice. The rice looked very good. It came with some jollof rice that had green peas in it and basically two small parts of chicken wings or just one whole wing...* I don’t want to sound too harsh, but **this is probably the worst jollof rice I have had this year or maybe in my life. The jollof was bland. It didn’t have any flavour at all.** Even the smallest seasoning wasn’t there. It didn’t taste like any jollof I’m familiar with. The best way to describe it is that it tasted like airplane food, the kind of rice you just force yourself to eat... I think they should just stick to making chicken and chips or burgers. **I’ll give the rice a 2/10.** The chicken wasn’t bad, but it’s definitely not like the usual KFC chicken (Brian Nwana - KFC).

The excerpt is an example of a negative emotion-based review on rice and chicken. The rice in the excerpt is jollof rice. The use of "worst jollof rice I have had this year or maybe in my life" clearly indicates the food critic's strong dissatisfaction with the rice, highlighting it as "bland and lacking flavor". The description of the rice as "bland" further emphasises the lack of seasoning. The comparison to "airplane food" shows just how unappetizing the food critic found the rice, meaning it was something they had to force themselves to eat rather than enjoy. The statement "didn't taste like any jollof I'm familiar with" points to how the rice did not match the food critic's expectations. Even though the chicken wasn't completely bad, the food critic said it was "definitely not like the usual KFC chicken," suggesting it did not meet the usual quality. The rating of 2/10 reflects how unhappy the food critic was with his dish.

**(iii) Appreciation and hybrid evaluations** – Appreciation has to do with the assessment of the food. The food influencers express their satisfaction with their food experiences while assessing the food. This is evident in phrases like “*very good*,” “*well-seasoned*,” and “*authentic oha*”. Hybrid evaluations combine positive and negative assessments within a single review. This strategy aligns with Martin and White (2005), who argue that hybrid appraisal allows speakers to balance credibility and audience engagement. It also reflects the nuanced nature of culinary evaluation in a digital context (Unuabonah, 2018).

#### **Excerpt 7**

##### **Food review on Afang, Oha and Ekpang nkukwo**

*... I got this food from afang Uyo in Abuja. I got some afang soup, oha soup, and Ekpang Nkukwo with friends. I also got akpu and fufu whatever you prefer to call them. It started off with tasting the afang Soup, and to be honest, I liked it a lot. It reminded me of the one I had during service. I liked the way the vendor prepared it. It was spicy, and **the seasoning was very good**. The **goat meat in the soup was also very very good**. Oha used to be one of my best soups while growing up, so I decided to get it from the vendor. **The oha tasted like authentic oha**. The leaves were not overcooked, and the flavor was very good. My only problem is **that the oil was just a little bit too much** in the soup. I also tried ekpang nkukwo for the first time. I can't lie; I really enjoyed it. It is basically cocoyam wrapped in vegetables, all in one. I definitely enjoyed trying out South-South soups because they are some of my bests in Nigeria. Fisherman Soup is also one of my top favorites".* **(Brian Nwana in Afang Uyo's Restaurant)**

The excerpt is an example of a hybrid emotion-based review on soup. The soups in this excerpt are *Afang*, and *Oha*. The phrase "very, very good" shows a high intensification, indicating that the food reviewer was very pleased with the goat meat in the afang soup. The nominal group "authentic oha" suggests that the oha soup was made in a traditional style, which the food reviewer appreciated. The phrase "the flavour of the oha was very good" supports that the reviewer enjoyed the taste of the oha soup. On the negative side,

"a little bit too much" indicates a low intensification, showing that the food reviewer had an issue with the amount of oil in the oha soup. While the soup's flavour was good, the food reviewer found the oil to be excessive. This highlights evaluative precision and reflects the critic's knowledge of culturally expected food standards. These are in line with the findings of Wislocka Breit, 2014 and Akintode, 2023.

### Excerpt 8

#### Food review on Amala

*I recently visited the famous Amala Sky again, but this time at their new branch in Abuja .... I ordered amala, Ope went for egusi with pounded yam, and Maria also got amala... **the amala itself was so smooth and soft.** It was a very good amala. Honestly, I preferred this amala to the one I had in Lagos last year. **I'll give it a 7/10.** Now, let's talk about the soup. It was okay. **It was mildly spiced and seasoned properly, but I would have preferred it to be spicier.** It needed that kick to really bring everything together. **The real issue I had was with the kpomo.** That kpomo **was so hard**, I was struggling. It was as if I was possessed trying to chew it. It really messed with my whole experience. **I'll rate the kpomo 2/10. It was barely edible.** The other proteins were good. **The goat meat was soft, and the assorted meat was also good.** So, no complaints there. As for **the place itself, it's really nice.** They even sell Arabian tea, and I think that's such a cool touch. I would definitely recommend checking them out, but I **seriously hope they work on that kpomo.** (Brian Nwana - Amala Sky)*

This excerpt is a hybrid review on soup and swallow and the swallow in this excerpt is amala, describing it as "so smooth and soft" and "very good". These positive reviews show a satisfaction with the quality of the amala. However, the food reviewer mentions that he would have preferred the soup to be "a lot spicier" suggesting that the seasoning did not meet his expectations. A major concern in the review is the kpomo, which the food reviewer found to be "so hard" and "barely edible." This negative comment highlights a problem with the texture of the kpomo. Despite this, the food reviewer speaks positively about the other proteins, such as the "goat meat" and "assorted", calling them "soft" and "good". This mix of positive and negative comments shows that the review is hybrid in nature. The food reviewer gives the amala a 7/10 rating and the kpomo a 2/10, showing a clear difference in quality. They end with a suggestion for improvement, advising the restaurant to "work on their kpomo." The food reviewer also mentions that the restaurant has a "really nice place" and serves "Arabian tea," which balances the negative comments and shows appreciation for other aspects of the experience.

### Excerpt 9

#### Food review on spaghetti and chicken, fried rice and turkey, sweet tea and porridge

*Today, we are trying Michy's Special...We started with the porridge. **I took a bite, and it was actually really good.** The flavours were on*

point. My only issue was that **the yam was a little too stiff for me**. I personally like my porridge really soft, to the point where it melts in my mouth. Now, **for the meat, this was seasoned very well**. Like, the seasoning entered deep inside and it was absolutely good. It wasn't plenty, but it was still satisfying. **For the porridge, I'll rate it 7.5/10**. Next, we tried the spaghetti, which came with a pepper sauce. But for me, **it tasted more like maggi sauce than actual pepper sauce**. I took my first bite, and here's the thing: the flavour was actually nice, **but it was over-seasoned like, it was right on the edge**. As for the **chicken, it was soft and tender, but a little bit under-seasoned**. Now for the fried rice just from the look of it, it already looked perfect. And yes, **it did taste good**. A lot of well-defined flavours came together nicely. **As for the turkey, it was seasoned perfectly**. No complaints...For the fried rice, **I'd give it 7.8/10**. The fried rice was definitely my favourite out of everything. For the total package, **I'd rate it 7.6/10**. (Eat with Timi - Michy's Special)

This is a hybrid review on spaghetti and other dishes like fried rice, porridge, chicken, turkey, and assorted meat. The adjectival group “really good” shows the food critic was pleased with the taste. The meat that came with the porridge was “seasoned very well,” indicating it was spiced properly and well-prepared. The chicken was also described as “soft and tender,” suggesting a good texture. The fried rice “looked perfect,” and the taste was described as “good,” with “well-defined flavours.” The turkey was said to be “seasoned perfectly,” which also shows satisfaction. The ratings reflect the positive and negative aspects of the review. The porridge gets a 7.5/10 despite the yam being too stiff. The fried rice stands out with a solid 7.8/10. Even though the food critic gave some positive reviews, there were some complaints. For instance, “a little too stiff,” indicates a dissatisfaction with the texture of the rice. The spaghetti was “over-seasoned,” indicating that the dish was heavily seasoned, which may have negatively impacted the taste. The chicken was described as “a little bit under-seasoned,” implying that it lacked enough flavour. The spaghetti's over-seasoning brings it down to 6.9/10. The fried rice stands out with a solid 7.8/10, and the chicken, being under-seasoned, affects the overall rating. This brings the overall ratings to a 7.6/10. The food reviewer was satisfied with some aspects of the food but not with some other aspect.

### 3. Contextual and cultural embeddedness of reviews

The analysis reveal that evaluations are highly context-dependent, reflecting Nigerian cultural and regional food practices. Lexical items such as “*amala*, (swallow eaten in the Southwest, represents the Yoruba culture)” “*banga*” (soup eaten in the South-South - Delta State), *Oha* soup (soup eaten in the South-East, represents the Igbo culture), *Suya* (spiced meat specially prepared by Northerners, represents the Hausa culture) “*afang*, (soup eaten in South-South, in Akwa Ibom State)” are markers of cultural identity and authenticity. The food influencers' responses are shaped by shared socio-cultural expectations about taste, texture, and preparation methods (Belasco, 2008; Tribaldos et al., 2018). For example, Excerpt 7 highlights both appreciation (“*the goat meat was very*,

*very good*") and mild dissatisfaction ("*oil was just a little bit too much*"), reflecting the critic's negotiation of local culinary standards and personal preference. The excerpt is an example of a hybrid emotion-based review on soup. The soups in this excerpt are afang, oha and ekpang nkukwo. The phrase "very, very good" shows a high intensification, indicating that the food reviewer was very pleased with the goat meat in the afang soup.

The nominal group "authentic oha" suggests that the oha soup was made in a traditional style, which the food reviewer appreciated. The phrase "the flavour of the oha was very good" supports that the reviewer enjoyed the taste of the oha soup. On the negative side, "a little bit too much" indicates a low intensification, showing that the food reviewer had an issue with the amount of oil in the oha soup. While the soup's flavour was good, the food reviewer found the oil to be excessive. This supports the view that culinary discourse is not just about taste but also a culturally situated evaluative practice, consistent with Akintode (2023), who shows that Nigerian food reviews blend emotive engagement with cultural knowledge. Furthermore, widely consumed dishes like jollof rice, suya, and pounded yam illustrate a shared national culinary identity, while regional specialties like *ofe oha* reinforce ethnic and regional identities.

### **Discussion of findings**

This study set out to examine how selected food influencers construct meaning through language in culinary discourse, with particular attention to syntactic features, emotional evaluations, and cultural context. The findings reveal that food criticism in the Nigerian digital space is a highly evaluative, culturally embedded, and linguistically strategic practice. A major finding is the dominance of affect over judgment and appreciation in the critics' feedback. Across the data, food influencers relied more heavily on emotional expressions such as "I love," "I enjoyed," "very disappointed," and "I really like" to communicate their experiences. This aligns with the position of Unuabonah (2018), who notes that food discourse, particularly in informal digital contexts, is often driven by emotive engagement rather than detached evaluation. The prominence of affect suggests that food influencers on Instagram position themselves not merely as evaluators but as experiencers, foregrounding personal taste and emotional reactions to build relatability with their audience.

Closely related to this is the extensive use of graduation resources, especially intensifiers such as "very," "really," "so," and "literally." These linguistic items amplify both positive and negative evaluations, thereby strengthening the persuasive force of the reviews. For instance, expressions like "very very soft," "absolutely good," and "worst jollof rice in my life" demonstrate how food influencers scale their experiences to signal strong approval or disapproval. This supports Martin and White's (2005) claim that graduation is central to interpersonal meaning, as it enables speakers to adjust the intensity of their stance and align audiences with their evaluations.

Another important finding is the systematic use of syntactic structures—particularly nominal and adjectival groups—in encoding evaluation. Nominal groups such as "the texture," "the taste," and "the flavour" serve as focal points for assessment, while adjectival groups like "very soft," "well-seasoned," and "too tough" provide qualitative judgments. These patterns indicate that food critics rely on descriptive precision to anchor subjective experiences in seemingly objective linguistic forms. This reinforces the

idea that culinary discourse operates at the intersection of subjectivity and descriptive realism, where personal impressions are framed as observable qualities.

The study also reveals the prevalence of hybrid evaluations, where positive and negative comments coexist within the same review. Rather than offering absolute judgments, food influencers frequently balance praise with criticism, as seen in statements like “the rice was good, but the chicken was too tough.” This pattern reflects a nuanced evaluative strategy that enhances credibility. By acknowledging both strengths and weaknesses, food influencers construct an image of fairness and expertise, which is crucial in digital environments where audiences value authenticity.

Furthermore, the findings highlight the role of engagement resources, particularly through conversational markers, rhetorical questions, and audience-directed expressions such as “guys,” “I won’t lie,” and “you guys won’t believe.” These features position the influencers as interactive rather than monologic, simulating a dialogue between the influencers and the audience. This supports the view that social media discourse transforms traditional food criticism into a participatory and relational practice, where meaning is co-constructed with viewers. Beyond linguistic features, the study underscores the centrality of cultural context in shaping food evaluations. The frequent reference to culturally specific dishes such as *amala*, *afang*, *egusi*, and *banga* demonstrates that food criticism in Nigeria cannot be separated from cultural identity.

Critics draw on shared cultural knowledge to evaluate authenticity, taste, and preparation methods. For example, describing a dish as “authentic oha” or criticising jollof rice for not meeting expected standards reflects culturally grounded expectations. This finding supports the argument by Belasco (ibid) that food practices and preferences are deeply embedded in cultural systems of meaning. Importantly, the study shows that food reviews function as more than mere assessments of taste; they act as sites of cultural negotiation and identity construction. By referencing regional dishes (Igbo, Yoruba, Urhobo, and Efik-Ibibio cuisines), food influencers implicitly affirm the diversity and richness of Nigerian culinary heritage. At the same time, widely consumed foods like jollof rice and suya serve as symbols of a shared national identity, illustrating how culinary discourse contributes to both cultural differentiation and national cohesion. Finally, the findings suggest that food influencers on Instagram adopt a performative style of evaluation, characterised by exaggeration, humour, and vivid comparisons (e.g., “I wouldn’t give my dog this,” “fighting for my life”). These expressions enhance entertainment value while intensifying evaluation, indicating that digital food criticism operates within an attention economy where engagement is as important as accuracy.

## Conclusion

This study explored how selected Nigerian food influencers construct meaning and express evaluative judgments in Instagram-based culinary discourse. The analysis demonstrates that food reviews are not merely descriptions of taste, but linguistically and culturally complex communicative acts. The key findings indicate that evaluative meaning is primarily realised through nominal, adjectival, adverbial, and verbal groups, with affective expressions dominating over judgment and appreciation. Food influencers frequently employ graduation resources, including intensifiers, repetition, and numeric ratings, to amplify stance, producing positive, negative, and hybrid evaluations. Hybrid

evaluations, in particular, balance praise and critique, enhancing credibility and audience engagement. These linguistic strategies align with Appraisal Theory (Martin & White, 2005) and are supported by Systemic Functional Linguistics, which provides the grammatical basis for realising evaluative meaning.

The study further highlights the cultural embeddedness of culinary evaluation. Food influencers draw on shared knowledge of Nigerian dishes to assess taste, texture, preparation, and authenticity, reflecting both regional and national culinary identities. Dishes such as *amala*, *afang*, and *egusi*, serve as cultural markers, demonstrating how food discourse negotiates both ethnic and collective identity, while also conveying social norms and expectations regarding quality. In sum, Instagram-based food reviews by selected Nigerian food influencers function as emotionally charged, culturally informed, and linguistically strategic evaluations. They illustrate the interplay between language, evaluation, and culture, showing that culinary discourse is a site for both personal expression and cultural negotiation. The study contributes to scholarship on digital discourse, pragmatics, and food studies by integrating grammatical analysis, Appraisal Theory, and cultural context, and it underscores the significance of language in shaping perceptions of culinary practices in contemporary Nigeria.

## References

- Akintode, O. N. (2023). A pragmatic analysis of advertisement of groceries in selected Nigeria print media. *Ilaro Journal of Humanities and Management*.
- Al-Azzawi, Q. O., & Abdulameer, A. H. (2020). *Pragmatic analysis of directives in food recipes*. *PalArch's Journal of Archaeology of Egypt / Egyptology*.
- Atkins, P., & Bowler, I. (2016). *Food in society: Economy, culture, geography*. Routledge.
- Belasco, W. (2008). *Food: The key concepts*.  
<https://www.researchgate.net/publication/345072060FoodTheKeyConcepts>.
- Betancourt-Núñez, A., Nathaly, T., Martínez-López, E., Loera-Rodríguez, C., et al. (2022). *Emotional eating and dietary patterns: Reflecting food choices in people with and without abdominal obesity*. *Nutrients*, 14(7), 1371.  
<https://doi.org/10.3390/nu14071371>
- Breur, S. (2019). *A genre analysis of restaurant reviews: Differences between reviews written by professional critics, experienced consumers and inexperienced consumers* (Master's thesis, Tilburg University). Tilburg University.
- Burgess, J., & Green, J. (2009). *YouTube: Online Video and Participatory Culture*. Polity.
- Huseynova, N., Amani, B., & Taghiyev, I. (2022). *The critical discourse analysis in the persuasive language of hotel and fast-food restaurant advertisements*. *Khazar Journal of Humanities and Social Sciences*, 25(2), 107–121.
- Lindström B., Bellander M., Schultner D. T., Chang A., Tobler P. N., Amodio D. M. (2021). A computational reward learning account of social media engagement. *Nature Communications*, 12(1), Article 1311. <https://doi.org/10.1038/s41467-020-19607-x> Google Scholar
- Martin, J. R., & White, P. (2005). *The Language of Evaluation: Appraisal in English*.
- Marwick, A. E. (2015). *Instafame: Luxury selfies in the attention economy*. *Public Culture*, 27(1), 137–160.

- Metzler, H, and Garcia, D. (2023) Social Drivers and Algorithmic mechanisms on Digital media. *Perspectives on Psychological Science*. Sage Journals. 19 (5).  
<https://doi.org/10.1177/1745691623118505>
- Remley, D. T., Kaiser, M. L., & Osso, T. (2013). A Case Study of Promoting Nutrition and Long-Term Food Security Through Choice Pantry Development. *Journal of Hunger & Environmental Nutrition*, 8(3), 324–336. Retention. *Journal of Marketing*, 69(4), 210–218 <https://doi.org/10.1509/jmkg.2005.69.4.210>
- Rousseau, S. (2012). Food Media: Celebrity chefs and the politics of everyday interference.
- Tribaldos, T., Jacobi, J., & Rist, S. (2018). Linking sustainable diets to the concept of food system sustainability. *Current Opinion in Environmental Sustainability*, 32, 39–45.
- Unuabonah, F. (2018) Plantains I love them so” Appraisal choices in Nigerian Food Blogs. In Foluke Unuabonah, Kehinde Ayoola, Adeyemi Adegoju (Eds) *Explorations in critical discourse and new media studies: Essays in honour of Rotimi Taiwo*. Galda Verlag, Glienicke, Germany.
- Vo Thi My Linh, & Nguyen Thi Quynh Hoa. (2024). A study of "attitude" in English restaurant reviews from the perspective of appraisal theory. *UD-JST*.  
<https://doi.org/10.31130/ud-jst.2024.438E>
- Wislocka Breit, B. (2014). *Appraisal theory applied to the wine tasting sheet in English and Spanish*. *Ibérica*, (27), 97–120.